



Owning the moment: Duplantis celebrated for the cameras with a finger-pistol salute, inspired by Turkish shooter and Paris Olympics silver medallist Yusuf Dikec. REUTERS

For now, Duplantis is so far ahead of the rest of the field, he can continue to break the world record one centimetre at a time. But just how far can he go? Is the sky really the limit for him?

As easy as he makes it seem, the fact is that the higher Duplantis goes, the harder it gets to get even that one centimetre of height. Duplantis reflects on its scale: "It's so marginal, but makes more of a difference than you can imagine," he says. "Even if it's one centimetre, it gets to a certain point where you hit it and it suddenly becomes so much more difficult."

The fact that he's literally in a league of his own means Duplantis ends up having to compete in two separate competitions — having to beat everyone else first, then getting to target the world record. Whereas others might build up from their

competition-winning height to the world record, Duplantis has no option but to go straight for it. This completely flips the physical and mental demands. Just like in Silesia, he has to make a couple of jumps while the rest of the field does their things, and then all of a sudden, he will have to be prepared to jump higher in quick succession.

But as his jumps in Silesia and in Paris earlier this year have shown, there's still a lot of height left in him. At both competitions, Duplantis failed his first attempt at the world record, not because he didn't clear the height but because he landed on them on the way down. When he did clear the height successfully, there were

several inches between his chest and the bar on the downward journey.

"I don't think he's at his peak right now. He's only 24, and pole vaulters typically peak in their late 20s to early 30s," coach and father Greg told *Red Bull.com*. "He's still getting stronger, and I think he's going to be better in four years than he is now. He's already jumping higher than anyone ever has, and to predict how high he can jump is crazy. This probably does sound crazy, but I think he can get close to 6.40 m. If not 6.40m. But it will require a lot of work."

That mark may be several years into the future. There are going to be a lot of shiny rings and shinier medals for Duplantis to collect until then.



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